[Shaikh Ala'i's] Mahdawi disciples'.[13]

Among them was the unfortunate Shaikh Mubarak, who would spend the next twenty-odd years entangled in the snares of his 'inveterate enemy'.[14] If Shaikh Mubarak hoped that the fall of the Suri dynasty would also spell the end of its pre-eminent theologian, he was out of luck. Makhdum-ul-Mulk retained his high rank in the early decades of Akbar's reign, and continued his persecutions. Indeed, the 'hatred of the court party [against Shaikh Mubarak] rose to such a height'[15] at this time that Abul Fazl's father, having already lost his position in court and his grants of land, also almost lost his life.

Badauni was no friend of Abul Fazl's or his family's, but he was, like many, a Mahdawi; and no admirer of the court ulema, whom he regarded as being more invested in power than in theology. Of Makhdum-ul-Mulk, for example, he writes that the supposed scholar looked upon his books 'as bricks'.[16] Badauni tells the story of Shaikh Mubarak's troubles with sympathy, therefore, writing that this was a time 'when it was customary to get hold of, and kill such as tried to introduce innovations in religious matters'.

Thus, Makhdum-ul-Mulk – along with another increasingly powerful cleric called Shaikh Abdun Nabi – sent policemen to arrest Shaikh Mubarak. The scholar was hiding with his young sons, so the police broke the 'pulpit in his prayer room'. Terrified, the shaikh appealed to Salim Chishti, but the Sufi saint had yet to acquire any influence over Akbar. He could only advise Shaikh Mubarak to leave Agra. Eventually, it was Akbar's milk brother and friend Aziz who intervened and saved the shaikh and his family.

For the moment, the shaikh and his sons were safe; but they lived on tenterhooks. Sometime later, Shaikh Mubarak's elder son, Faizi, was summoned to Chittorgarh – 'carried off'[17] by an aggressive contingent of soldiers. It wasn't until he came face to face with the emperor that Faizi knew whether he was being punished for his father's beliefs or rewarded for his increasingly popular poetry.

Fortunately, it was Faizi's poetry that had caught Akbar's eye. Faizi and his father must have breathed a sigh of relief; neither could have known how much their fortunes were about to change.